considering the big picture, and seek resolution.' The Indians agreed saying the 'two sides have sharp differences . . . one method is to place the [officials'] reports to one side and ignore them, while both sides proceed from a political angle to reconsider [the issues]'. Significantly, the Indian team added: 'But the difficulty lies in swaying popular opinion.'[37] That both countries should be mindful of the strategic–diplomatic 'big picture' had been expressed by the Chinese before. In 1954, in a meeting with Nehru, Mao had said, 'We are a new country. Although we are counted as a large country, our strength is weak. Confronting us is a larger power America . . . therefore we need friends. PM Nehru can feel this. I think India also needs friends.'[38] In a démarche to India in May 1959 over its supposed role in the Tibet uprising (a démarche that was written by Mao personally), the Chinese had urged India to recognize the strategic challenges facing both countries:

> The enemy of the Chinese people lies in the East . . . India is not an opponent but a friend of our country . . . China will not be so foolish to antagonize the US in the East and again to antagonize India in the West. Our Indian friends! What is your mind? Will you be agreeing to our thinking regarding the view that China can only concentrate its main attention eastwards of China but not South-West-ward of China . . . Friends! It seems to us that you too cannot have two fronts . . . Will you please think it over?[39]

In 1959 and then again in 1961, India failed to be persuaded by the strategic argument that China advanced.

Why so? Indian officials in Beijing had hinted at one difficulty: popular opinion at home. Also, as we will see in the next chapter, by 1955–56, Delhi was more comfortable diplomatically with both Moscow and Washington and had concluded that the balance of power internationally favoured it in the emerging rivalry with Beijing. This too, probably, caused India to be cool to the Chinese idea of strategic necessity. Finally, as in 1947–48 on Kashmir, India felt confident – at least by 1960 – that its legal position was strong, indeed unassailable. It should have learned from its experience in the UN – that legalism only went so far and that ultimately the big powers operated on the basis of hard strategic calculations. The apparently unassailable Indian case on Kashmir had failed to persuade the international